Vertical slice plan: one Berlin mission, end to end

Summary. The smallest thing that proves Thin Ice is one playable Act I mission in Berlin, with the painted close-view look, long planning turns, partial intel, one strategic interlude and one humour event, both before and after the mission. It reuses most of Cold Synapse's engine (the deterministic simulation, planning, Test preview, replay and AI), and adds an isometric renderer with height levels, sight cones and noise, a small campaign state, and an interlude screen. It is built in six steps, each of them playable and tested, with a screenshot at the end of each. Nothing is built until you say go.

What the slice must prove

- **The planning loop works at the new scale:** long turns, sight cones, noise, doors and height, with a Test preview you can trust.
- **The two layers talk:** a decision in the interlude changes the mission, and the result changes the next interlude.
- **The tone works:** dry humour in the briefing and a human, never cruel, handling of the people in it.
- **The look works in the engine,** not only in mock-ups: painted world, neon information layer, green highlight, ring only on the selected unit, strength bars, and partial enemy intel.
- **Consequences carry over,** felt only in the following mission, as decided.

Scope (and what is deliberately left out)

In the slice	Left out for now
One mission, 'The Café Handover', Berlin, night; 4 agents, about 8 guards and 6 civilians, one two-level building (roof and street)	Other cities, other acts, the hex and world maps
Sight cones with height, noise, doors, a body that can be found; Light and Dark play	Combat beyond a few shots and one fight; vehicles
Partial intel on the guards (type, route, alertness), shown as unknown or crossed out	Spy networks, counter-espionage mission
Interlude with the four tracks (supply, resolve, trust, intel), three decisions and one humour event card	The full strategic layer and branching
Morale of the four agents as a status detail, with the first two levels of its effects	Reserves, home front, veterancy
Play as the Western side; a mirrored Eastern version of the same mission as a switch	A second, different campaign for the other bloc
Save, load and replay; automated tests like Cold Synapse	Sound, music, voice, final fonts

What is reused and what is new

Reused from Cold Synapse	New work
Deterministic simulation core, seeded rules, Test preview on a copy, replay frames and events	Isometric renderer with depth sorting, lighting, shadows and height levels
Waypoints, aim, stance, wait, check, ignore and focus orders; pathfinding	Sight cones that respect height and doors; noise; found bodies; alertness levels
Computer opponent that tests plans on a copy of the game	Guard routines (patrols that turn into hunting) as the opponent's plans
Mission data as JSON, objectives and events	Campaign state, interlude screen, event cards, partial-intel rules
Test and screenshot tooling	Painted-style assets generated in code and a procedural figure set

Milestones

#	Deliverable	Done when
M1	Isometric board with the Berlin block, agents and guards as figures, the ring on the selected unit, strength bars	A screenshot matches the Vienna mock-up closely; the engine runs it at a steady frame rate
M2	Planning in the new view: waypoints, aim, stance, wait, check, with the hidden orders bar and the right-click menu	A scripted test plans and previews a full turn
M3	Sight cones with height and doors, noise and found bodies; guards with patrol routines	Tests show a guard noticing an agent in sight and ignoring one behind a door
M4	Partial intel and morale levels on guards and agents, deterministic	A replay is identical every time; unknown fields are crossed out as designed
M5	Interlude: the four tracks, three decisions, one humour card, and the effect on the mission start	A different decision gives a visibly different mission start
M6	Full loop: interlude, mission, result grade, next interlude, with save and load and the double view (Western and Eastern side)	A complete playthrough, with a PDF of screenshots for your review

Risks and honest unknowns

- **Art:** a painted look in code is an approximation. If it does not feel close enough once it runs, an artist or art pipeline may be needed, and that is a decision I would raise at M1.
- **Isometric rules:** hit-testing, occlusion and height levels are harder than top-down. M1 and M3 are where I would expect surprises.
- **Fun is unproven:** the planning loop is proven in Cold Synapse, but stealth with long turns is new. A first playable at M2 or M3 is the earliest honest test.
- **Effort:** I can't give days. In terms of working sessions I would expect each milestone to take one to three, so the whole slice is roughly ten to fifteen sessions.
- **Cold Synapse comes first:** it still waits on your Blackout list, polish items and feedback on the restyle.

Decisions I need from you before M1

- Is 'The Café Handover' in Berlin the right first mission, or do you prefer Vienna or London?
- Western side first, with the mirrored Eastern version as a switch, or the other way round?
- May I start Thin Ice in the same repository (a separate folder), or do you want a new repository?
- Do you want Cold Synapse finished first, or should Thin Ice start in parallel?